Households' Inflation Expectations Survey

Today, the Reserve Bank released the results of September 2026 round of its bi-monthly Inflation Expectations Survey of Households (IESH)[1] [2]. The survey was conducted during September 10-20, 2026, in 19 major cities, with 5,987 responses.

Highlights:

i. The current median inflation perception of households increased by 60 basis points (bps) to 8.4 per cent as compared to the previous round [Charts 1a and 1b; Table 3].

ii. Households' median inflation expectations for the next three months and one year rose by 70 bps and 60 bps to 9.9 per cent and 10.0 per cent, respectively [Charts 1a and 1b; Table 3].

iii. The proportion of respondents anticipating a rise in general inflation has inched up for both the time horizons [Tables 1(a) and 1(b)].

Chart 1a. Median Inflation Rate - Perception and Three Months ahead Expectation

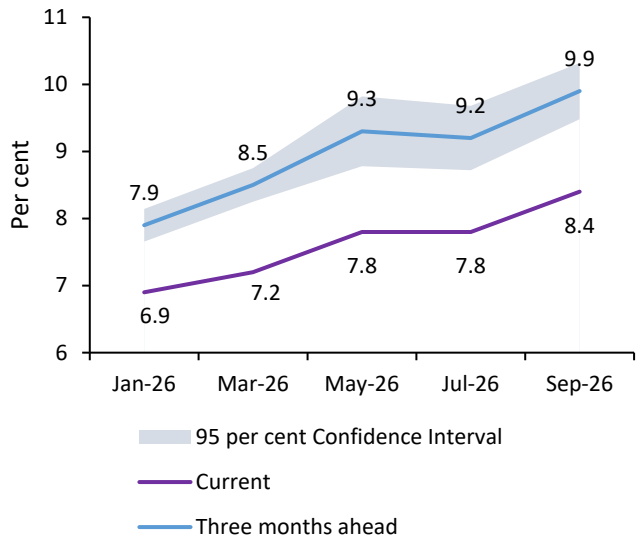
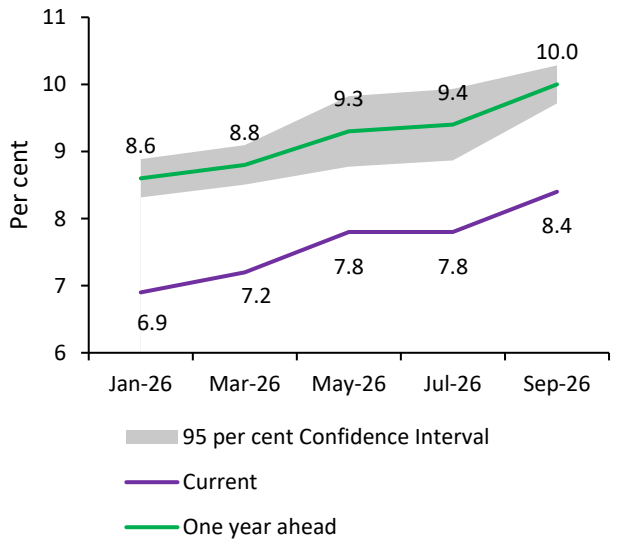


Chart 1b. Median Inflation Rate - Perception and One Year ahead Expectation



Note: Please see the excel file for time series data[3]

[1] The survey is conducted at bi-monthly intervals by the Reserve Bank; it provides directional information on near-term inflationary pressures as expected by respondents and may reflect their own consumption patterns. Hence, survey results reflect respondents' views, which are not necessarily shared by the Reserve Bank.

[2] All estimates of inflation perceptions and expectations are given in terms of median, unless stated otherwise.

[3] Results of the previous survey round were released on the Bank's website on August 05, 2026. Unit-level data for previous rounds of the survey are available on the Bank's 'Database on Indian Economy' (DBIE) portal (weblink: https://data.rbi.org.in/DBIE/#/dbie/home) under the head 'Unit-level Data'.

Table 1(a): Product-wise Expectations of Prices for Three Months ahead										
									(Percentage of Respondents)	
Survey period ended	Sep-25		Mar-26		May-26		Jul-26		Sep-26	
General	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE
Prices will increase	77.8	0.90	81.6	0.90	83.5	0.78	80.7	0.92	81.9	0.90
Price increase more than current rate	51.5	1.20	57.2	1.21	60.4	1.16	57.1	1.21	59.0	1.15
Price increase similar to current rate	23.1	0.89	20.9	0.85	19.7	0.90	20.8	0.93	19.3	0.87
Price increase less than current rate	3.1	0.36	3.6	0.40	3.4	0.40	2.8	0.34	3.6	0.42
No changes in prices	18.5	0.85	16.8	0.89	14.0	0.71	17.4	0.89	16.2	0.86
Decline in prices	3.7	0.43	1.5	0.24	2.5	0.32	1.9	0.28	1.9	0.26
Food Product										
Prices will increase	79.0	0.90	83.8	0.75	85.4	0.73	84.2	0.77	84.9	0.78
Price increase more than current rate	51.5	1.22	59.4	1.16	60.7	1.13	60.0	1.16	61.6	1.03
Price increase similar to current rate	22.2	1.00	18.4	0.81	18.6	0.83	18.8	0.88	17.7	0.77
Price increase less than current rate	5.3	0.45	6.0	0.52	6.0	0.52	5.4	0.46	5.6	0.50
No changes in prices	14.2	0.80	12.4	0.68	10.4	0.61	11.9	0.69	10.8	0.67
Decline in prices	6.8	0.53	3.8	0.37	4.1	0.38	3.9	0.36	4.3	0.39
Non- Food Product										
Prices will increase	73.4	0.91	77.6	0.90	81.1	0.78	79.3	0.87	79.4	0.84
Price increase more than current rate	49.4	1.19	54.0	1.15	56.8	1.16	55.4	1.20	55.8	1.07
Price increase similar to current rate	18.7	0.89	18.1	0.77	18.7	0.83	18.8	0.87	18.4	0.79
Price increase less than current rate	5.3	0.45	5.5	0.45	5.6	0.49	5.0	0.44	5.2	0.44
No changes in prices	20.1	0.80	19.0	0.86	14.6	0.69	16.5	0.80	16.7	0.77
Decline in prices	6.5	0.54	3.4	0.34	4.3	0.40	4.3	0.40	3.9	0.37
Household Durables										
Prices will increase	67.8	0.97	65.4	1.00	68.2	0.97	67.5	1.02	69.6	0.99
Price increase more than current rate	49.5	1.16	44.7	1.11	46.8	1.14	46.5	1.14	49.3	1.08
Price increase similar to current rate	14.1	0.69	15.9	0.69	16.9	0.79	16.7	0.77	16.2	0.69
Price increase less than current rate	4.2	0.39	4.9	0.44	4.5	0.42	4.2	0.40	4.1	0.40
No changes in prices	21.5	0.83	25.6	0.91	24.3	0.87	26.2	0.96	22.6	0.88
Decline in prices	10.7	0.62	9.0	0.56	7.5	0.51	6.3	0.46	7.7	0.49
Cost of Housing										
Prices will increase	77.1	0.88	78.4	0.90	78.3	0.87	77.9	0.89	78.4	0.90
Price increase more than current rate	54.9	1.15	57.8	1.14	56.3	1.13	56.7	1.13	58.8	1.11
Price increase similar to current rate	18.9	0.87	17.0	0.73	18.0	0.83	17.5	0.81	16.3	0.75
Price increase less than current rate	3.4	0.34	3.6	0.37	4.0	0.42	3.6	0.36	3.3	0.35
No changes in prices	18.7	0.81	19.1	0.88	18.4	0.80	19.5	0.87	19.0	0.83
Decline in prices	4.2	0.41	2.5	0.30	3.3	0.36	2.6	0.29	2.6	0.32
Cost of Services										
Prices will increase	66.1	1.00	69.8	1.01	71.1	0.92	68.6	1.03	69.7	1.00
Price increase more than current rate	46.2	1.17	48.7	1.14	49.1	1.16	48.6	1.14	49.6	1.11
Price increase similar to current rate	15.7	0.72	17.2	0.72	17.4	0.80	16.5	0.78	16.1	0.71
Price increase less than current rate	4.2	0.40	3.9	0.37	4.5	0.47	3.4	0.35	3.9	0.36
No changes in prices	30.0	0.98	27.9	0.98	25.5	0.88	28.5	1.00	27.7	0.97
Decline in prices	3.8	0.43	2.3	0.28	3.4	0.38	2.9	0.34	2.7	0.29
Note:										
1. The table provides estimates and standard errors (SE) for qualitative responses.										
2. Constituent items may not add up to the corresponding total, due to rounding off.										

Table 1(b): Product-wise Expectations of Prices for One Year ahead										
									(Percentage of Respondents)	
Survey period ended	Sep-25		Mar-26		May-26		Jul-26		Sep-26	
General	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE
Prices will increase	86.8	0.79	90.0	0.66	86.9	0.76	88.7	0.74	88.9	0.73
Price increase more than current rate	61.8	1.22	67.5	1.19	63.6	1.23	66.1	1.21	67.4	1.13
Price increase similar to current rate	21.7	0.94	19.6	0.88	19.7	0.90	19.9	0.94	18.5	0.84
Price increase less than current rate	3.3	0.36	2.8	0.35	3.6	0.41	2.7	0.34	3.0	0.36
No changes in prices	10.0	0.70	8.3	0.61	10.1	0.65	9.0	0.67	9.2	0.68
Decline in prices	3.2	0.41	1.7	0.27	3.0	0.38	2.2	0.29	1.8	0.26
Food Product										
Prices will increase	83.3	0.95	87.4	0.68	85.9	0.73	87.0	0.74	86.2	0.74
Price increase more than current rate	56.5	1.34	61.1	1.19	59.0	1.23	59.9	1.23	61.3	1.07
Price increase similar to current rate	22.8	1.03	21.5	0.88	22.2	0.94	22.7	0.96	20.6	0.83
Price increase less than current rate	4.0	0.41	4.8	0.45	4.7	0.48	4.4	0.41	4.3	0.42
No changes in prices	11.5	0.80	9.3	0.60	9.6	0.59	9.6	0.67	9.8	0.64
Decline in prices	5.2	0.49	3.2	0.36	4.4	0.42	3.3	0.34	3.9	0.37
Non- Food Product										
Prices will increase	79.7	0.96	83.7	0.79	82.7	0.81	83.1	0.80	82.9	0.82
Price increase more than current rate	53.6	1.27	58.6	1.18	56.7	1.24	58.2	1.23	58.2	1.11
Price increase similar to current rate	21.6	0.96	21.2	0.85	21.6	0.94	20.8	0.92	21.1	0.85
Price increase less than current rate	4.4	0.42	3.9	0.40	4.5	0.44	4.1	0.40	3.6	0.37
No changes in prices	15.4	0.84	13.4	0.73	13.1	0.67	13.5	0.72	13.2	0.73
Decline in prices	4.9	0.46	2.9	0.33	4.1	0.44	3.4	0.35	3.8	0.36
Household Durables										
Prices will increase	78.1	0.90	75.3	0.92	75.0	0.92	75.7	0.90	76.9	0.91
Price increase more than current rate	58.0	1.17	52.6	1.19	51.5	1.22	52.6	1.22	54.9	1.14
Price increase similar to current rate	16.5	0.81	18.6	0.79	19.6	0.88	19.6	0.87	18.0	0.77
Price increase less than current rate	3.7	0.37	4.1	0.42	3.8	0.39	3.5	0.38	4.1	0.42
No changes in prices	14.2	0.72	18.7	0.80	18.7	0.81	18.9	0.82	17.7	0.83
Decline in prices	7.7	0.57	6.0	0.45	6.3	0.48	5.4	0.43	5.4	0.43
Cost of Housing										
Prices will increase	87.5	0.70	89.4	0.60	87.0	0.73	88.0	0.66	87.5	0.73
Price increase more than current rate	63.8	1.14	67.0	1.08	64.3	1.12	66.0	1.16	66.4	1.06
Price increase similar to current rate	20.3	0.93	18.5	0.80	19.0	0.83	18.9	0.90	17.9	0.77
Price increase less than current rate	3.4	0.35	3.9	0.41	3.7	0.41	3.1	0.34	3.2	0.33
No changes in prices	9.1	0.58	8.9	0.56	10.1	0.60	9.6	0.59	10.2	0.66
Decline in prices	3.4	0.39	1.7	0.25	2.9	0.38	2.4	0.30	2.3	0.28
Cost of Services										
Prices will increase	81.2	0.83	82.6	0.78	81.3	0.87	80.7	0.90	81.5	0.85
Price increase more than current rate	58.4	1.15	57.2	1.15	56.4	1.21	57.0	1.25	57.9	1.13
Price increase similar to current rate	18.5	0.83	20.8	0.83	20.6	0.92	19.9	0.87	19.6	0.83
Price increase less than current rate	4.4	0.41	4.6	0.43	4.3	0.41	3.8	0.39	3.9	0.40
No changes in prices	15.4	0.77	15.4	0.75	15.3	0.77	16.4	0.83	16.2	0.79
Decline in prices	3.4	0.42	2.1	0.27	3.4	0.42	2.9	0.34	2.4	0.28
Note:										
1. The table provides estimates and standard errors (SE) for qualitative responses.										
2. Constituent items may not add up to the corresponding total, due to rounding off.										

Table 2: Inflation Expectations of Various Groups: Sep-26												
	Current Perception				Three Months ahead Expectation				One Year ahead Expectation			
	Mean		Median		Mean		Median		Mean		Median	
	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE
Overall	9.1	0.11	8.4	0.14	10.1	0.10	9.9	0.21	9.7	0.12	10.0	0.14
Gender-wise												
Male	9.3	0.13	8.6	0.20	10.3	0.13	10.1	0.16	9.9	0.16	10.1	0.14
Female	9.0	0.14	8.3	0.22	10.1	0.14	9.8	0.28	9.8	0.17	10.0	0.21
Category-wise												
Financial Sector Employees	9.6	0.46	8.7	0.81	10.5	0.49	9.6	1.12	10.4	0.56	10.3	1.02
Other Employees	9.1	0.19	8.4	0.24	10.1	0.19	9.7	0.35	9.7	0.23	9.8	0.36
Self Employed	9.4	0.22	8.7	0.32	10.3	0.22	10.1	0.26	9.7	0.26	10.2	0.27
Homemaker	8.8	0.16	8.2	0.23	9.9	0.17	9.7	0.33	9.6	0.19	10.0	0.23
Retired Persons	9.9	0.36	9.6	0.69	10.7	0.36	10.4	0.28	10.1	0.42	10.2	0.45
Daily Workers	9.5	0.29	9.1	0.59	10.6	0.31	10.4	0.25	9.9	0.35	10.3	0.25
Other category	8.4	0.21	7.7	0.27	9.5	0.22	9.0	0.36	9.5	0.26	9.3	0.44
Age Group-wise												
Up to 25 years	8.2	0.19	7.4	0.23	9.3	0.20	8.5	0.20	9.3	0.24	8.9	0.28
25 to 30 years	8.9	0.19	8.3	0.29	9.9	0.20	9.9	0.27	9.9	0.24	10.2	0.15
30 to 35 years	8.9	0.21	8.3	0.30	9.8	0.22	9.2	0.47	9.6	0.26	9.8	0.40
35 to 40 years	9.1	0.21	8.3	0.29	10.2	0.21	10.0	0.36	9.8	0.25	10.0	0.34
40 to 45 years	9.1	0.22	8.2	0.30	10.1	0.23	9.5	0.48	9.5	0.27	9.6	0.49
45 to 50 years	9.8	0.25	9.8	0.42	10.8	0.26	10.5	0.15	10.3	0.31	10.4	0.27
50 to 55 years	9.5	0.28	9.8	0.46	10.7	0.31	10.5	0.17	10.0	0.36	10.4	0.22
55 to 60 years	9.5	0.30	9.3	0.75	10.4	0.31	10.3	0.27	9.0	0.39	9.0	0.76
60 years and above	9.6	0.28	9.2	0.62	10.5	0.27	10.3	0.31	9.8	0.31	10.0	0.51
City-wise												
Ahmedabad	8.1	0.39	7.0	0.31	9.2	0.44	8.2	0.40	8.8	0.49	8.0	0.42
Bengaluru	6.4	0.21	5.5	0.07	8.1	0.23	7.3	0.26	8.4	0.26	7.9	0.24
Bhopal	9.7	0.55	9.2	1.11	10.6	0.50	10.4	0.32	9.6	0.62	10.0	0.71
Bhubaneswar	9.2	0.87	8.9	1.17	11.1	0.72	10.8	1.35	11.1	0.92	11.1	1.17
Chennai	8.0	0.36	7.0	0.51	9.3	0.33	8.7	0.52	9.8	0.41	10.1	0.40
Delhi	10.6	0.27	10.3	0.16	11.1	0.26	10.7	0.22	10.2	0.29	10.6	0.23
Guwahati	8.0	0.68	7.4	1.03	8.4	0.57	7.8	0.70	9.4	0.76	8.9	0.80
Hyderabad	9.0	0.26	8.6	0.67	10.5	0.27	10.2	0.36	10.2	0.36	10.3	0.33
Jaipur	7.8	0.21	7.9	0.26	8.5	0.30	8.3	0.39	8.5	0.49	8.6	0.37
Jammu	9.4	1.28	9.2	1.49	9.4	0.96	9.2	1.21	9.8	0.89	9.8	0.94
Kolkata	10.9	0.39	10.6	0.15	11.7	0.37	12.0	1.06	10.6	0.35	11.2	0.78
Lucknow	8.6	0.33	8.3	0.47	9.1	0.36	8.8	0.53	9.2	0.48	9.8	0.61
Mumbai	9.2	0.37	8.6	0.44	10.3	0.36	10.2	0.35	10.0	0.41	10.5	0.37
Nagpur	8.8	0.32	8.6	0.44	10.4	0.48	10.1	0.87	10.0	0.87	11.2	2.05
Patna	8.0	0.64	6.9	0.66	8.5	0.65	7.7	0.61	8.3	0.67	7.6	0.73
Thiruvananthapuram	7.8	0.90	6.2	0.84	9.5	0.91	8.5	1.17	10.9	0.92	10.5	1.18
Chandigarh	9.1	0.57	8.9	1.26	9.5	0.51	9.4	1.00	7.4	0.74	7.3	1.43
Ranchi	8.4	0.33	7.6	0.20	8.8	0.35	8.2	0.26	8.5	0.63	8.4	0.50
Raipur	11.2	0.78	10.7	0.94	12.4	0.75	12.7	1.69	11.8	0.94	13.5	1.62
Note: The table provides estimates and standard errors (SE) for quantitative responses.												

Table 3: Household Inflation Expectations – Current Perception, Three Months and One Year Ahead Expectations												
	Current Perception				Three Months ahead Expectation				One Year ahead Expectation			
	Mean		Median		Mean		Median		Mean		Median	
	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE
Sep-25	8.4	0.08	7.4	0.13	9.0	0.08	8.1	0.11	8.8	0.11	8.7	0.16
Nov-25	7.7	0.08	6.6	0.14	8.4	0.08	7.6	0.10	8.1	0.10	8.0	0.15
Jan-26	7.8	0.08	6.9	0.16	8.9	0.09	7.9	0.12	8.9	0.11	8.6	0.15
Mar-26	8.2	0.09	7.2	0.13	9.3	0.09	8.5	0.13	9.1	0.11	8.8	0.15
May-26	8.5	0.09	7.8	0.13	9.7	0.09	9.3	0.27	9.2	0.11	9.3	0.27
Jul-26	8.6	0.09	7.8	0.14	9.7	0.10	9.2	0.24	9.3	0.12	9.4	0.27
Sep-26	9.1	0.11	8.4	0.14	10.1	0.10	9.9	0.21	9.7	0.12	10.0	0.14
Note: The table provides estimates and standard errors (SE) for quantitative responses.												

Table 4: Households Expecting General Price Movements in Coherence with Movements in Price Expectations of Various Product Groups: Three Months Ahead and One Year Ahead					
					(Percentage of Respondents)
Survey period ended	Food	Non-Food	Household durables	Housing	Cost of services
Three Months Ahead					
Sep-25	59.6	63.8	65.3	64.3	71.8
Nov-25	62.4	62.6	55.1	62.1	65.4
Jan-26	65.9	66.6	60.0	64.8	68.6
Mar-26	65.5	66.5	59.0	64.6	66.4
May-26	66.6	67.4	59.4	63.9	66.6
Jul-26	66.4	67.4	62.3	66.0	68.7
Sep-26	68.0	68.1	62.8	65.4	68.7
One Year Ahead					
Sep-25	75.5	67.8	71.4	69.7	73.0
Nov-25	83.4	70.3	61.7	71.0	71.1
Jan-26	71.7	71.0	64.5	73.0	72.8
Mar-26	73.6	73.8	68.0	74.7	74.2
May-26	74.3	72.7	67.4	74.1	73.8
Jul-26	74.1	74.0	68.7	74.5	74.7
Sep-26	75.0	73.9	70.4	74.7	76.5

Table 5(a): Cross-tabulation of Number of Respondents by Current Inflation Perception and Three Months Ahead Inflation Expectations: Sep-26																			
	Three Months Ahead Inflation Rate (per cent)																		
		<1	**1-<2**	**2-<3**	**3-<4**	**4-<5**	**5-<6**	**6-<7**	**7-<8**	**8-<9**	**9-<10**	**10-<11**	**11-<12**	**12-<13**	**13-<14**	**14-<15**	**15-<16**	**>=16**	**No idea**	**Total**
Current Inflation Rate (per cent)	<1	7	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	**8**
	1-<2	1	19	24	7	0	1	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	**53**
	2-<3	2	9	103	86	34	14	2	0	1	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	**252**
	3-<4	0	3	10	87	82	59	10	2	0	2	2	0	0	0	0	0	0	**257**
	4-<5	0	2	5	11	126	102	61	20	15	0	4	0	0	1	0	1	0	**348**
	5-<6	0	0	16	21	20	385	200	226	115	7	111	0	0	1	0	3	2	**1108**
	6-<7	0	0	1	3	2	7	146	106	78	18	30	2	3	0	0	0	0	**396**
	7-<8	0	0	0	4	4	5	9	174	106	51	63	2	3	1	2	0	2	**426**
	8-<9	0	0	5	2	0	3	3	1	161	64	163	18	31	3	3	5	2	**464**
	9-<10	0	0	1	1	1	2	2	0	3	75	40	19	27	7	5	6	7	**196**
	10-<11	0	1	0	2	4	27	4	5	10	6	440	52	213	44	16	221	92	2	**1139**
	11-<12	0	0	0	0	1	1	0	0	0	0	3	13	6	7	7	2	2	0	**42**
	12-<13	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	49	5	9	27	11	0	**102**
	13-<14	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	7	2	5	4	0	**18**
	14-<15	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	5	6	3	0	**14**
	15-<16	0	0	1	0	2	3	0	0	0	0	11	0	0	0	1	95	154	0	**267**
	>=16	0	1	1	2	0	6	0	0	1	0	24	0	2	1	0	22	832	5	**897**
	Total	**10**	**36**	**167**	**226**	**276**	**615**	**437**	**534**	**490**	**223**	**894**	**106**	**334**	**77**	**50**	**393**	**1111**	**8**	**5987**

Table 5(b): Cross-tabulation of Number of Respondents by Current Inflation Perception and One Year Ahead Inflation Expectations: Sep-26																			
	One Year Ahead Inflation Rate (per cent)																		
		<1	**1-<2**	**2-<3**	**3-<4**	**4-<5**	**5-<6**	**6-<7**	**7-<8**	**8-<9**	**9-<10**	**10-<11**	**11-<12**	**12-<13**	**13-<14**	**14-<15**	**15-<16**	**>=16**	**No idea**	**Total**
Current Inflation Rate (per cent)	<1	4	2	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	**8**
	1-<2	10	6	19	9	5	2	1	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	**53**
	2-<3	42	4	56	62	50	26	4	0	3	0	4	0	0	0	0	0	1	**252**
	3-<4	31	0	3	42	55	84	22	6	7	3	1	0	0	1	1	0	1	**257**
	4-<5	36	0	2	12	52	95	72	31	33	4	8	1	1	0	0	0	1	**348**
	5-<6	108	0	7	7	13	194	159	220	139	33	200	4	2	1	0	16	3	2	**1108**
	6-<7	46	0	0	1	2	5	79	72	93	30	52	4	7	3	0	2	0	0	**396**
	7-<8	48	0	1	1	3	4	6	95	73	62	91	3	22	4	1	9	3	0	**426**
	8-<9	45	0	1	1	3	2	0	4	74	48	155	26	65	6	4	19	11	0	**464**
	9-<10	22	0	0	0	1	0	1	1	1	37	32	19	31	9	9	16	16	1	**196**
	10-<11	110	0	0	2	1	10	2	5	5	2	252	36	176	40	24	303	170	1	**1139**
	11-<12	5	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	2	0	9	5	4	7	8	2	0	**42**
	12-<13	9	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	23	6	10	28	25	0	**102**
	13-<14	3	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	4	2	5	4	0	**18**
	14-<15	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	2	3	7	0	**14**
	15-<16	24	0	0	0	0	3	0	0	0	0	2	0	0	0	1	75	162	0	**267**
	>=16	109	0	1	1	0	3	0	0	2	0	12	0	1	1	2	16	745	4	**897**
	Total	**653**	**12**	**91**	**138**	**185**	**428**	**346**	**434**	**430**	**222**	**810**	**102**	**335**	**79**	**63**	**500**	**1151**	**8**	**5987**